

Women in Aquaculture

Mentoring Best Practices Guide

For Mentors & Mentees in Aquaculture

Women in Aquaculture (WiA)

Published 2025 | womeninaquaculture.org

This publication is produced by Women in Aquaculture (WiA), a global non-profit platform connecting, supporting and celebrating women across the aquaculture industry.

Why Mentoring Matters

Mentoring is one of the most effective ways to support career development, build confidence, and create lasting professional connections. In aquaculture, where women are underrepresented in leadership, mentoring can be transformative.

Research shows that women with mentors are promoted more often, earn higher salaries, and report greater career satisfaction. For mentors, the relationship offers fresh perspectives, leadership development, and the reward of giving back.

For Mentors

Core Principles

- Listen more than you advise — understand your mentee's goals first
 - Share your failures as well as successes — vulnerability builds trust
 - Help expand their network by making introductions
 - Set regular meeting times and honour them
 - Ask open-ended questions to encourage reflection
 - Celebrate progress, no matter how small
 - Respect boundaries — guide, don't direct
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For Mentees

Getting the Most from Mentoring

- Come prepared with clear questions or topics
- Be open about your challenges — honesty enables help
- Take notes and follow through on actions
- Respect your mentor's time — be punctual
- Don't be afraid to ask for what you need
- Own your choices — your mentor guides, you decide

Structuring Your Sessions

Month 1: Getting Started

Share backgrounds, set expectations, agree on communication preferences and meeting frequency. Discuss what success looks like for both of you.

Months 2-3: Goal Setting

Define 2-3 specific goals for the mentoring relationship. Create an action plan with milestones. Identify potential obstacles and strategies.

Months 3-5: Working Phase

Deep dives into challenges, skill development, and networking opportunities. Regular check-ins on progress. Adjust goals if needed.

Month 6: Reflection

Review progress against goals. Discuss what worked well and what could improve. Plan how to maintain the relationship going forward.

Remote Mentoring Tips

Many WiA mentoring pairs are in different countries. Tips for making remote mentoring work:

- Use video calls when possible — face-to-face matters
- Send a brief agenda 24 hours before each meeting
- Keep a shared document for notes, goals, and actions
- Be flexible with scheduling across time zones
- Supplement sessions with informal messaging check-ins